

Evaluate the Results

By now you’ve seen it yourself: AI makes mistakes. It uses the same confident voice whether the facts are right or wrong. So what do you do with an AI answer, knowing it might be wrong?

One option is to ignore AI. Pretend it doesn’t exist. Nobody who’s made it this far in the course is doing that: AI is too powerful to leave on the shelf. To **Be Smarter Than the Tool**, you need the right skills to evaluate AI’s results.

EVERY RESPONSE: THE QUICK PASS

Three steps, a few seconds, every time. This is the floor for anything AI hands you.

1

Read

This might sound obvious, but weak AI users take AI’s output and pass it along without reading it. Reading every word is the floor.

2

Understand

You’ll never know whether an answer is right if you don’t understand what it says. Usually, the best explainer is the same AI: “Explain the second paragraph in simpler terms.”

3

Validate

As you read, hold the answer up against your own knowledge. A well-stocked brain is your fastest fact-checker.

THEN DECIDE: DOES THIS ANSWER DESERVE THE DIG?

Most chats end at the quick pass. Three questions tell you when this one shouldn’t:

1

Could you actually validate it?

If it held up against things you genuinely know, you may be done. If it’s beyond what you know, keep going.

2

What kind of task was this?

Tasks that involve facts often need more evaluation. A first draft or a brainstorm usually doesn’t: you’re just checking it against what you asked for.

3

How much is riding on it?

Picking a movie for tonight: you’re done. A college essay, a health question, anything with your name on it: keep going.

WHEN IT DESERVES THE DIG

Some answers you can’t validate on your own, and some carry real stakes. Those get the deep evaluation. Here are the tactics:

**Ask for citations**

“Give me citations in your response.” Click the links: does the page exist and actually say what AI claims? Is it a reputable source? And if one claim checks out, don’t assume the rest do.

**Challenge the AI**

Ask it to argue the other side, or to flag what it’s least sure of.

**Ask what’s missing**

An answer can be all true and still narrow. One question surfaces what never made the page.

**Ask for a live web search**

AI’s built-in knowledge has a cut-off date, so on anything recent, have it check the live web.

**Leave the chat**

Search the claim yourself. If you can only find it inside the chat, treat it as unproven.

THEN MAKE YOUR MOVE

An evaluation isn’t finished until you act on it. Every one ends in one of three moves.

**Use it**

It passed your checks. Most answers end here. Read, understood, validated, done.

**Fix it**

Something’s off and you can name it. Say exactly what’s wrong in a follow-up: “cut the stat I never gave you,” “make it shorter.”

**Walk away**

Wrong tool, or stakes too high. Do it yourself, or take it to a person who actually knows: a teacher, a doctor, a pro.

EVERY RESPONSE:

THE QUICK PASS

Three steps, a few seconds, every time.

1

Read

Read every word. This is the floor for anything AI hands you.

2

Understand

Explain the answer in simpler terms. If you don’t understand it, neither does AI.

3

Validate

Check it against what you know. A well-stocked brain is your fastest fact-checker.

**Ask for citations**

Ask for sources. Click the links. Check the claims.

**Challenge the AI**

Argue the other side or flag what seems off.

**Ask what’s missing**

What else could be true? What never made the page?

**Ask for a live web search**

Check anything recent or anything AI might have missed.

**Leave the chat**

If you can’t verify it here, step away and find better info.

**Use it**

It passed your checks. Most answers end here. Read, understood, validated, done.

**Fix it**

Something’s off or incomplete. Say exactly what’s wrong and ask AI to fix it.

**Walk away**

Wrong tool or stakes too high. Do it yourself, or take it to a person who knows.

**Be Smarter Than the Tool.** Use AI like a pro.

The tool answers. You evaluate.

Read. Understand. Validate.